6.0. SOCIAL CONSTRUCTION OF GENDER

6.1. Introduction

Sex refers to the biological attributes of being male or female, while gender refers to the socially constructed attributes of being male or female, or of femininity and masculinity. Women and men are treated unequally on the basis of their sex and underlying the different treatment of women and men is /are complex ideologies that seek to explain (and create) the differences between men and women. Sex differences are often cited as the basis for **unequal treatment**, while in actual sense they represent socially constructed norms regarding the division of labor and distribution of power, responsibilities and rights between men and women. While the differences continue to be traced back to biological differences, it is obvious that the biological differences between men and women are minimal and insignificant when compared with the similarities.

Reading assignment- capture the biological difference between men and women

6.2. Biological Differences and Ideology of Gender

Biological difference becomes magnified to represent an ideology of sex difference called the ideology of gender, which is used to justify unequal treatment of women and men. The power of the ideology of gender lies in the way it encompasses fundamental cultural and social values relating to the relations between men and women and the force of history underlying its evolution. The historicity (historical actuality) and cultural variations found in the construction of gender relations points to the fact that these are changeable. In particular, the ideology of gender determines:

i. What is expected of us
ii. What is allowed of us
iii. What is valued in us

The ideology of gender also determines the nature and extent of three Ds (disadvantage, disparity and discrimination). On its part, the manifestation of gender difference can be found in the construction of:

i. Roles-what women and men do
ii. Relations-how women and men relate to each other
iii. Identity-how women and men perceive themselves

The ideology of gender thus contains norms and rules regarding appropriate behavior and determines attributes, while reproducing a range of beliefs and customs to support these norms and social rules. Norms and rules have material consequences for issues of women and men's relative access to and claims over different categories of resources. The normative foundations of sex difference lead to differences in the way responsibilities are allocated, resources are distributed, and rights are granted. As such, inequalities thus grow to represent *conflicts of interest*, so that challenges to the way social rules are constructed represent challenges to the entire organization of society. How men and women negotiate these changes will vary depending on the ability or capacity of men and women to risk changes to the way their lives have been lived. Three categories of coping strategies that we commonly engage in can be identified:

i. Acceptance
ii. Adaptation (involving negotiation and bargaining)
iii. Resistance

6.3. Social Rules & the Production of Gender Inequality

An analysis of the ideology of gender differences shows that the social construction of differences between men and women is the basis on which rules, resources, responsibilities, power and rights are distributed between women and men in society resulting in discrimination. Hence discrimination is socially constructed and is based on social rules/norms (the ways of doing things or patterns that become routine over a period of time). These patterns are so socially legitimized that they become reproduced and transferred from one generation to another, however with amendments. Four main institutions in society combine their practice and reinforce the ideology of the social construction of gender:

i. The Family or household
ii. The Market
iii. The community
iv. The state

For example, a social rule or norm is that men are breadwinners and women are home makers or that men are leaders and decision makers and women are followers and implementers of decisions. In accordance with the rules, starting from the household, women are expected to be obedient, submissive and fulfill household responsibilities while remaining in the background, which has serious consequence for women. Denial of chances to the woman for education by the family leads to fewer options in the work place or the fact that women are solely responsible for childcare in the family leads to disapproval of working women and women who seek market place substitutes for child care. Women are denied participation in community decisions, and in turn have limited rights in household decisions as they are seen as not having enough exposure or on the grounds that it is not their role.

Because of their lack of decision-making powers and capacity in the public sphere, women are unable to influence the market. Their lack of decision-making in the public sphere also means that they are denied valuable economic and political rights by the state. Because of the disadvantages they face women in turn are unable to influence the state as critical political constituencies. In the foregoing manner, a cycle of discrimination is established and justified on the basis of the expectations of society with regard to women and men. The denial of equality and rights for women is based on biological difference as well as a notion of equivalent rights: men have a right to education to earn a living, while women are economically provided for by men-gendered structures are so entrenched that it is uneconomical to do things differently-in some cases, it is seen as culture-destructive.

The picture that unfolds illustrates the manner in which social norms and values interact and influence each other to keep women in a disadvantaged position with regard to privileges, rights and power. The allocation of responsibilities, resources and rights on the basis of social norms disadvantages women materially. Furthermore such allocations on the basis of social norms contradict the reality of women's lives. For example, it is not true that women do not need economic resources because they are being provided for, nor is it true that all men provide for their family. It is also critical to realize those social rules and norms impacts on women in different ways depending on their class, level of education, caste/background and the social environment in which they live. As a result, we need to determine how women's rights are regulated across all institutions and try to reform these institutions.

Social rules are so entrenched that not only do women who deviate from them get "punished", but women are often seen to participate in their own subordination. The power of social rules lies in the fact that they appear to be consensual and non-negotiable, while in fact they are based on inequality and power equations. The whole debate around equality and rights for women is countered by a number of disagreements raised, which range from citing biological difference to equivalence to the cost of social change. We need to unpack the link between discrimination against women and the structural basis of inequality by looking at the way social rules are structured in different institutions of society. These are important to consider because gender relations are present in all of these institutions, and they are fundamentally interlinked.

Institutions do not function as isolated units of society but instead draw on the rules structured within the household and society. Assumptions that the household, community institutions, the market and the state are all independent of each other masks the extent to which gender differences are constructed and reproduced. The model of social organization used in law and policy is often based on the separation of these different institutions. This has led to the constant demarcation of spheres of activity into the public and the private. The private sphere is seen to be the domain of women, while

the public sphere that of men. Gendered distinctions of this kind point to the power of the ideology of sex difference. The construction of gender roles within social institutions becomes extended to the organization of women's activities. For example, the fact that women's reproductive functions are carried out within the sanction or legitimacy of the household is further extended to include all functions relating to child rearing to the same institution.

6.4. Social Construction of Gender

Our conception of what women and men are and what they are supposed to be is produced by the society in which we live i.e. who men and women are in terms of their behavior, roles, responsibilities and expectations is a function of what the society implants in them-*gender is socially constructed*. The day-to-day, continuous production of gender, which has been termed *doing gender* means that gender is *made* by us as part of the society in our interactions with one another. The English professional term *doing gender* implies that the affiliation and identification with one gender, usually occurs as a constant social process and can be found in all human actions. *Doing Gender* refers to the social application of the differentiation of the sexes and the interactions in which gender is manufactured. The ability to direct individual action so that the processes carried out match the allocation made, describes the process of *doing gender*. In general, women and men, boys and girls behave like they think they should.

The socialization process that starts at birth turns out to be the basis for gender allocation. The gender identity is awarded resistance in which, for example, a boy from time to time exhibits himself as a boy and announces his counterpart as belonging to the male sex. Thus a boy not only has a gender, but he proves it and allocates it to others from time to time. In this process at least two people are constantly involved, a person representing their gender and another that recognizes it accordingly. One's own staging is successful if a girl or a boy, in relation to others, could demonstrate their gender in a credible way.

The constant and everyday process of *doing gender* provides the basis for our gender relations to be regarded as normal.

Processes of doing gender are not only carried on in our society by individuals, but also through socially-standardizing practices such as legislation or the social institutions of the family, religion, government, school, etc. In the course of their lives, people are made either women or men in a complex process of socialization through inculcation of social norms and values, stereotypes, identification, images and traditions. Nonetheless, the conceptions of women and men are subject to change over time. Since their existence, the theories of socialization employs the central question of how people develop individuality and whether or what impact the environment has on this maturation process. The starting point is the hypothesis that man is by birth antisocial (an animal) and only becomes a social animal through socialization process. It is clear that human behavior is shaped by man when he submits to social demands of the society in which he is a member.

Until about 50 years ago, the opinion prevailed that the differences between men and women are induced by nature and are biologically grounded. Men are *controlled by reason* and women's behavior is mainly *driven by feelings*. Thus, the difference between the sexes was explained through their behavior. In the late 1960s, the realization prevailed that the social cultural proportion of the applied gender role is greater than the biological predisposition. In consequence the practiced gender role is not static, but flexible and changeable. It became increasingly clear that through social learning and interaction, values and norms were being mediated on the gender identity.

The social construction of gender behaviors has a complex history in which many factors, interactions and social processes are involved. They are manufactured by expectancies, attributions, sanctions and the promotion of certain attitudes and behaviors. A gender-

specific socialization is aided by the social institutions of the family, peer group, religion, school, government, economy, etc.

Find out how these social institutions influence social construction of gender behaviours.